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Welcome to Meridian Built Environment Ltd we are a multidisciplinary architecture and built environment consultancy founded in 2009 in Accra and over the years we have grown into one of the more recognised studios working on climate responsive design for the west african context, in 2017 we opened a second studio in Kumasi to be closer to projects in the middle belt. People often ask what we actually do and the honest answer is quite a lot, we take a project from the very first conversation about a piece of land all the way through to handing over the keys, our work covers feasibility studies concept design schematic design design development and full construction documentation, we have done everything from a 120 square metre private home for a returning diaspora client up to an eighteen thousand square metre mixed use development near the airport, no two briefs are the same which is exactly why we like the work.

our mission if you want it in one line is to design buildings that are comfortable durable and appropriate to their place without costing the earth, and we mean that both environmentally and financially.

a lot of clients come to us asking about cost first which is completely understandable. the honest truth is we cannot give you an accurate number until we understand your brief and your site, anyone who quotes you a precise figure on day one is guessing. as a very rough early guide mid spec construction in accra in 2024 has been running somewhere around four thousand five hundred to nine thousand ghana cedis per square metre but please treat that as order of magnitude only, it excludes the land and our fees and it moves around a lot with finishes and with the market and with whichever contractor you end up using. for a proper number you want a current QS estimate. on the subject of QS people sometimes assume we still do quantity surveying in house, we used to, but since january 2022 we outsource that to our partner firm adansi cost consult so please don't expect an in house QS from us anymore.

our fees. we quote per project after we understand the brief, there is no fixed price list, but as an indicative percentage of construction cost private residential work tends to land between seven and twelve percent, commercial and office between six and nine, institutional and public work six to ten, large mixed use is lower at five to eight because of scale, and interiors only work is higher at eight to fourteen percent. sustainability advisory we usually do as a fixed fee quoted against the scope. fees are exclusive of VAT and the associated levies which currently come to about twenty one point nine percent unless we say otherwise, and reimbursable expenses like printing travel outside greater accra and statutory fees are billed at cost. payment is staged against the work, typically fifteen percent when you appoint us, twenty percent at the end of concept design, twenty five at the end of spatial coordination, another twenty five at the end of technical design and the last fifteen spread across construction and handover. invoices are due within twenty one days, if you go past thirty days we may have to pause work. we take bank transfer and MTN mobile money, we do not take cash for

anything above two thousand cedis. for brand new clients with no prior relationship we ask for a fifteen percent non refundable retainer on appointment, and if you cancel you pay for the work done to date plus ten percent of the remaining fee.

how a project actually runs with us. we loosely follow the RIBA plan of work but we have adapted it for how things happen in ghana. it starts with strategic definition which is really just us listening to you and visiting the site and working out the goals, then preparation and brief where we do the feasibility and site analysis and a preliminary budget, then concept design where we usually put two or three genuinely different directions in front of you rather than three versions of the same idea, then spatial coordination where the developed design gets coordinated with the structural and services engineers, then technical design which is the full set of construction drawings and specifications, then construction itself where we visit site and answer the contractor's questions and certify progress, then handover with the snagging and as built records and the operation and maintenance manuals, and finally if you commission it separately a post occupancy review once you have lived in or used the building for a while. people always ask how long all this takes. for a small residence under three hundred square metres the design stages excluding permitting and construction are usually eight to fourteen weeks, a medium commercial job of a few thousand square metres is more like sixteen to twenty eight weeks, and anything large or mixed use over three thousand square metres is thirty weeks or more and usually phased. all of that depends heavily on how quickly you make decisions, the single biggest cause of delay we see is slow client sign off.

a quick reality check on what we do and don't do because this matters and we would rather be clear up front. we are architects and design advisors. we do not issue final structural sizing or foundation or reinforcement designs, a licensed structural engineer of record does that and stamps it, if we ever give you a preliminary size or a rule of thumb it is indicative only and must be checked by the engineer before anyone builds anything. we do not issue stamped code compliance sign off or fire and egress certification. we are not the contractor, we do not supervise the means and methods on site and we are not responsible for site safety, that sits with the principal contractor under the building contract, our staff do wear the hard hat and hi vis and boots when we visit but that is us following site rules not us running the site. and we cannot honestly guarantee that your project stays on budget, no one can, material prices and contractor pricing move all the time, what we can do is design to a target and flag the risks early and lean on our QS partner for the estimates.

on permits, yes we help, we prepare and coordinate the building permit drawings and the documentation but you the client are the applicant of record and you pay the statutory fees, and the approval timeline is set by the metropolitan municipal or district assembly not by us, in practice that has been anywhere from four to twelve weeks depending on which assembly and how busy they are.

sustainability is not a bolt on for us it is how we start. before anyone specifies mechanical cooling we screen the project for passive design, that means maximising cross ventilation, shading the west and east glazing properly, light coloured roofs, rainwater harvesting where it makes sense, and we aim for EDGE compliant which is the IFC and world bank green building standard that needs at least a twenty percent resource saving, on every new build where the client's budget allows it. we are EDGE experts ourselves but note we do not issue the energy compliance certificate, that has

to come from an accredited third party assessor, we just prepare the documentation for them.

some other things clients ask. can you work outside accra and kumasi, yes we work nationwide and we have done jobs in takoradi tamale and ho, travel outside greater accra and ashanti is a reimbursable expense. how long before i see designs, for a typical house expect first concept options about three to four weeks after you have signed the appointment and given us a complete brief. do you do 3d visualisations, yes, basic massing 3d is in the concept stage and the high end photoreal renders and walkthroughs are an add on. what climate do you design for, coastal projects we treat as warm humid tropical and northern projects as hot dry but we always confirm the actual site and microclimate before we lock anything in.

internal stuff for staff that also ended up in this export, the current drawing templates live on the server at MBE-FS01 under standards templates 2024 and you must use the 2024 title blocks, revit is our primary tool for anything over five hundred square metres and the naming follows the MBE BIM protocol document MBE-STD-007 while autocad is fine for small works and details, nothing leaves the office without the project architect and a director signing off and a recorded transmittal, the spec library is NBS style clauses adapted to ghanaian materials held under standards specs on the same server and you always region check whether the material is actually available here, and timesheets go into BQE core daily by project code submitted by friday four pm.

a few definitions that float around our documents in case you are new, AHJ is the authority having jurisdiction the body that enforces the code locally, EDGE is excellence in design for greater efficiencies the green building certification with the twenty percent savings threshold, FFE is furniture fixtures and equipment, MEP is mechanical electrical and plumbing, MMDA is the metropolitan municipal or district assembly that issues permits, O and M is operations and maintenance, PPE is personal protective equipment, RFI is a request for information which is the contractor's query during construction, RIBA is the royal institute of british architects whose plan of work we base our stages on, snagging is finding the defects to fix before handover, and VAT is the value added tax and the levies that go with it.

we reference a number of standards, the ghana national building regulations of 1996 which is LI 1630, the ghana building code GS 1207 from 2018, various ghana standards authority material standards, EDGE for the green building side, and we will reference eurocodes or the IBC for concepts where the local guidance is silent but the authority having jurisdiction and a licensed local professional are always the final word, codes change so always check the current edition and any local amendment and never assume a code figure from one country applies in another.

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